

Drama and disarray

In the face of the hostility of critics and the public, Schoenberg was supported by a small circle—notably, the young composers Alban Berg and Anton Webern. Both had been taught by Schoenberg and became valued colleagues, forming a group known as the Second Viennese School. The first performance of Schoenberg's *Pierrot Lunaire*, an Expressionist cabaret for five instrumentalists and voice, in 1912 was described by Webern as “an unqualified success.” In 1913, the belated first performance of *Gurre-Lieder* proved a triumph, but the composer refused to acknowledge the tumultuous applause, reluctantly mounting the stage only to stand with his back to the audience. He was no doubt more comfortable with what became known as the *Skandalkonzert* (Scandal Concert) later in the same year, when a performance of his Chamber Symphony, along with works by Berg, Webern, and Zemlinsky, provoked a riot, with fistfights breaking out in the audience.

These excitements of the Viennese avant-garde scene were interrupted by the outbreak of World War I in 1914. Schoenberg's first response was a startling expression of nationalism, denouncing French composers as “kitschmongers” and welcoming a chance to make them “venerate the German spirit.” His brief spells of army service disrupted his creativity without contributing to the Austrian war effort. His only major composition begun during the war, the oratorio *Jacob's Ladder*, was never completed.

After the war, he participated in a musical turn away from the emotional excesses of Expressionism toward a more orderly Neo-